# RISE OF THE VEGGIELANTES

**RELIGIOUS VIGILANTES ARE OPENING NEW FRONTS OVER MEAT-EATING EVEN THOUGH MORE THAN HALF THE COUNTRY IDENTIFIES AS NON-VEGETARIAN**

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*Photo illustration by* **NILANJAN DAS**

**Tucked into the bustling lanes of College Street in Kolkata** is an unassuming meat shop that old-timers say is more than a hundred years old. Inside it sits an idol of Maa Kali, the fierce and beloved goddess of Bengal. Each morning, she is propitiated with flowers, incense and chants; later in the day, she presides over business—the fresh mutton and other cuts sold over the counter. Outsiders may find this form of 'Kasai Kali' jarring but, for Bengalis, it's a seamless expression of faith and co-existence. As Bantu Singh, a shop fixture now, explains, "People don't understand our culture. When videos of our shop were posted online, many asked, 'How can there be an idol in a meat shop?' It's hard to explain to them."

But that which needs no explanation within Bengal—a riverine civilisation that has long celebrated its fish, meat and goddesses—is increasingly coming under scrutiny outside it. A recent incident in New Delhi's Chittaranjan Park, a predominantly Bengali locality, has ignited a fierce debate over culture, food and faith. Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra put out a video on social media showing a group of saffron-clad men confronting fish vendors near a Kali temple, telling them that selling fish near a place of worship was an affront to 'sanatan dharma'.

Moitra condemned the incident, calling the individuals "BJP goons" and accusing them of imposing a homogenised cultural norm alien to Bengal's ethos. "Never in 60 years (of CR Park) has this happened," she commented below the video before wading into how food habits are now being policed by right-wing elements.

The ruling BJP, however, rejected Moitra's allegations. Delhi BJP chief Virendra Sachdeva called the video "fake and manipulated", and accused Moitra of attempting to sow disharmony. He also demanded a police investigation into the video's "authenticity".

The Bengali residents of CR Park, though, say that such confrontations are becoming common, with reprobate elements even issuing warnings against eating meat and fish during Navratri. Notably, the fish market in the video falls under Market No. 1 in CR Park, and the adjacent temple was built by the market's shopkeepers—including the many fishmongers themselves!

## Food as Battleground

The CR Park incident is part of a broader trend across states where food habits—especially those involving meat and fish—are being dragged into the domain of identity politics. Large sections of forward castes, especially in the north of the country, have traditionally looked down on meat-eating and considered it 'impure'. However, despite these ham-handed attempts to impose cultural mores, India remains a largely non-vegetarian nation. According to the National Family Health Survey (NFHS) 2019-21, 83.4 per cent of men and 70.6 per cent of women in the 15-49 age group are non-vegetarians. Indeed, the corresponding numbers for 'pure vegetarians' were just 16.6 per cent and 29.4 per cent, respectively.

The fault lines stem from caste-based orthodoxy and manifests in thinly-disguised dog-whistling against minorities. Mumbai, once known as a melting pot and exemplar of cosmopolitanism, is a prime example where you could be denied accommodation in parts of the city if you are a meat-eater. The gentrification of Mumbai—with its soaring skyline and real estate prices—and the rise of gated